

ON THE CONSIDERATION OF ‘PUBLIC DIPLOMACY’ AS A RHETORICAL GENRE

Matthew G. Gerber, *Baylor University*

Abstract: In this article, I make a case for the consideration of public diplomacy as a rhetorical genre. While I concede that other fields (most notably political science) have provided meaningful insight into the function of public diplomacy, I conclude that due to the common suasive elements that recurrently appear in this type of discourse, rhetorical approaches to the study of public diplomacy are the most appropriate. I have identified four common characteristics that recur in public diplomacy, and I argue that these commonalities necessitate the consideration of public diplomacy as a genre of rhetoric.

The Emergence of ‘Public Diplomacy’

Considerable scholarly effort has been devoted to the interrogation of the issues surrounding the emergence of “public diplomacy.” As globalization, cultural pluralism, and mass information transmission converge, interest in the nexus of public communication and international relations has concurrently increased across multiple academic disciplines. In the process of coming to grips with the new public diplomacy, some of the recent work in this field has centered on resolution of the inevitable definitional ambiguities that accompany the rise of what some have even called a new academic discipline (Gregory, 2008). In particular, for scholars in the field of political science, the lack of clearly demarcated academic approaches to public diplomacy has been particularly troubling. Gregory (2008)

bemoaned a perceived dearth of seminal literature in the area of public diplomacy when he recently asked, “where is the academic research and where are the scholarly publications that would give meaning to a field of study?” (p.274). I argue that Gregory was perhaps premature when he indicated that “scholars have had little to say directly about public diplomacy until recently” (p.274). A closer look into the literature in the field of communication studies would have revealed a rich tradition of scholarship, particularly given that Gregory defined public diplomacy as a “communication instrument used in governance” whose primary purpose was to “engage and influence foreign publics” (p.276).

Similarly, Cowan and Cull (2008) mistakenly argued that public diplomacy had been “neglected in academic circles” and had been “dominated by practitioners, frequently with an institutional axe to grind” (p.7). In fact, public diplomacy has been investigated rigorously by scholars and critics (rather than solely by practitioners) in the field of communication studies for decades. Indeed, “scholars in rhetoric have produced a number of critical studies of foreign policy discourse” whose aim is to “reveal that foreign policy decision making is influenced powerfully by modes of persuasive appeal” (Beer & Hariman, 1996). Calling public diplomacy a “new field of practice and scholarship,” Gilboa (2008) argued that “while scholars have applied communication models to issues of foreign policy and international relations, only a few researchers have applied them to public diplomacy” (p.64). Gilboa fails to draw any distinction between ‘public diplomacy’ and the discourse of foreign policy and international relations. It seems that Gilboa’s ‘criticism’ concedes that scholars have a rich tradition of applying communication theories to the study of foreign policy rhetoric and the various discourses of international relations; both are variants of public diplomacy that could be classified in the same ‘genus’ of rhetoric.

While I disagree with the labeling of public diplomacy as an entirely new field of study, I support Gilboa's claim that "experts and practitioners in public diplomacy have often ignored relevant information in communication" (p.73). I argue that while it may be premature to attempt the categorization of public diplomacy as a new academic field altogether, and while public diplomacy and its study is certainly multidisciplinary, it may be useful to consider public diplomacy as a rhetorical genre. The categorization of public diplomacy as a rhetorical genre can hopefully begin to shed light on possible solutions to the definitional dilemmas associated with the birth of this area of study, and point to ways in which approaching public diplomacy from a communications perspective may be both practical and enriching to the enterprise.

'Generic' Rhetorical Criticism

A rhetorical genre, simply defined, is a category of discourse (Fisher, 1980). Critics categorize particular types of rhetoric based upon their similarities. There are many ways to group species of discourse together, and similarities in type can be based on multiple characteristics. A genre, by definition, is also a *generalization*, and is hence both true and untrue (Fisher, 1980). A generalization, about any object, image, or idea, describes only what is true *most of the time*. A generalization also then presupposes *exceptions to*, or *variations from* what is true *most of the time*. Fortunately, the boundaries and parameters of a given category of discourse need not be rigid or considered to be without exception. Indeed, one of the primary goals of generic criticism is to enable the critic to examine not only what fits within a particular genre, but also what does not fall within the category. Exceptions or deviations in the genre need not obviate the category, rather, the very aim of generic criticism is to "capture what is permanent, and what changes in discourse over time" (Fisher).

Traditional approaches to generic criticism broadly posit that the borders of any given category are determined by both the situation in which they arise and the types of rhetorical strategies that are called forth by the expectations of the audience within that situation. Harrell and Linkugel (1978) argued that the genesis of most rhetorical genres “stem(s) from organizing principles found in recurrent situations that generate discourse characterized by a family of common factors”, and that critics should attempt to highlight “strategic variations which consistently appear within a given genre of discourse” (p.263-4). That is, rhetors often find themselves in recurrent situations and the discourses engendered by those situations are often similar to patterns of rhetoric that have been employed in similar situations by rhetors past. Jamieson (1975) argued that rhetors were constrained by “antecedent “or previously occurring “rhetorical forms” (p.162). Campbell and Jamieson (1978) indicated that the “rhetorical forms that establish genres are stylistic and substantive responses to perceived situational demands” (p.19). Drawing upon earlier work by Fisher (1970), Harrell and Linkugel (1978) explicated four exigent situations which might create the need for a rhetorical response: affirmation, reaffirmation, purification, and subversion. *Affirmation* entails a situation in which a rhetor must convince an audience to change their minds, or embrace a new concept. *Reaffirmation* is a situation in which a communicator must galvanize or reinforce a perception already held by the audience. A situation in which a speaker seeks to “refine an image, idea, or concept” is referred to as *purification*. Finally, a situation in which a rhetor must persuade the audience to abandon or reject an ideology, image, or concept is defined as *subversion*. The present essay draws upon this taxonomy of generic situations/responses in order to demonstrate the ways in which it may be theoretically useful to situate public diplomacy as a rhetorical genre.

William Benoit's (2000) research on rhetorical genres marked a minor deviation from the situational approach. Benoit argued that while contemporary genre theory was useful in terms of providing critics a "benchmark to provide guidance" in the analysis of discourse, it overemphasized situation as "a single factor" to explain an "inherently complex rhetorical event" (p.178). Benoit turned to the work of Kenneth Burke to offer a 'corrective' to genre theory that sought to add the concepts of purpose, agent, and agency (in addition to scene or situation) to the list of factors or motives that could influence a rhetor's choice of styles or arguments. Benoit wrote that "these four Burkean ratios jointly account for the genesis of rhetorical action" (p.180). This essay also draws upon Benoit's work to provide insight into the manner in which public diplomacy could be framed and analyzed as a rhetorical genre.

Defining Public Diplomacy

Recently, scholars from across several disciplines have attempted to operationally define 'public diplomacy'. While no definitional consensus has been achieved, several studies have made clear the foundations and contours of what is meant by the term. The Center on Public Diplomacy, housed in the University of Southern California's Annenberg School of Communication, defined public diplomacy as "the amalgam of activities by which a transnational socio-political actor with standing in world politics openly and purposefully advances policy goals by seeking to influence, and engage with, foreign publics" (2009). This broad definition would include "educational exchange programs for scholars and students; visitor programs; language training; cultural events and exchanges; and radio and television broadcasting" (2009). Traditional modes of public diplomacy, such as public addresses by Presidents or diplomats would also be included in the aforementioned taxonomy. Cowan and Arsenault (2008) advocated a dialogic interpretation of public diplomacy which

emphasized the two-way communicative nature of contemporary diplomatic discourse. They argued that this relational model of public diplomacy is “what can and should separate public diplomacy from propaganda, lobbying, and public relations” (p.11). Indeed, ‘public diplomacy’ was “developed partly to distance overseas governmental information activities from the term propaganda, which had acquired pejorative connotations” (Center on Public Diplomacy, 2009). Under this view, public diplomacy is concerned with transnational relationship building through genuine communication rather than through ‘monologic,’ one-way ‘broadcasting’ of information.

Van Ham (2008) defined public diplomacy as a ‘place branding’ exercise, wherein the country’s image and national reputation are marketed and transmitted globally in the same way that a product would be. However, even proponents of the ‘public relations’ approach conceded that “public diplomacy comes in many shapes and guises but can be brought back to the strategy of appealing to the core values of foreign audiences” (Van Ham, 2008). Nye (2008) defined public diplomacy as a powerful tool to be employed by nation-states in the exercise of ‘soft power’. For Nye, a nation’s “soft power rests on the ability to shape the preferences of others” and to use “the power that comes from setting the agenda and determining the framework of a debate” (p.94). Nye, a political scientist, concluded that for public diplomacy to be effective, “it is crucial to understand the target audience” (p.103). Despite the myriad ways in which public diplomacy has been defined, the constant factor at the root of these approaches is the centrality of communication and persuasion. Public diplomacy is, at its core, a necessarily *suasive* endeavor, concerned with the influence of foreign audiences and the modification of their behavior in some way. It makes sense to analyze and unpack public diplomacy with the investigative tools germane to the field of communication studies.

Situating Public Diplomacy as a Rhetorical Genre

To identify public diplomacy as a rhetorical genre, I begin with a discussion of recurrent and similar situational constraints that help to determine both the substance and style of discourse. Rather than focusing on one extended example of discourse that exemplifies all of the generic characteristics of public diplomacy, I will use several examples of diplomatic rhetoric, drawn from the field of communication studies, in order to point to the diverse ways in which public diplomacy might be studied generically. First, public diplomacy is public, and not private. Public diplomacy is conducted in the open, and represents the work of transnational actors such as nation-states or their ‘citizen-diplomats’. To envision public diplomacy as a rhetorical genre, the first step for a critic is to identify similar patterns or characteristics that appear in the corpus of relevant discourse. Both the substance and style of public diplomatic discourse is influenced by the public nature of its location. To further draw upon the work of the aforementioned critics who chose to foreground situation as the guiding force in the categorization of rhetoric, I argue that the ‘public’ in public diplomacy *is* a situation that affects strategy choice. Indeed, because public diplomacy was increasingly being conducted in the open, and “exposed to public scrutiny in all its processes”, the consideration of how to control foreign public opinion suddenly became salient for policymakers during the Cold War (Gerstman, 1962). Benoit’s work is also instructional here in that a critic could approach public diplomacy of this sort from a Burkean scene-act ratio perspective, in which the physical location of the speech (or public broadcast) would have a direct bearing on which arguments were likely to be effective with the target audience. Finally, as early as the 1950s, scholars in communication studies were pointing to the importance of the *public* nature of transnational diplomacy. Commenting on the quickly evolving nature of global mass communications and its impact on the face of diplomacy and

the ways in which national identity was represented by diplomats, Simpson (1957) quipped, “it is remarkable how often the observation of an individual acquires an attribution to the entire nation” (p.13).

Second, public diplomacy largely occurs in response to the recurrent need to manage the national reputation. For example, when a foreign dignitary dies, it is necessary, indeed *required*, to send diplomatic condolences on behalf of the nation. This type of public diplomacy is both government-to-government, and government-to-public. In the context of contemporary international relations, failure to engage in the epideictic task of sending official condolences would send the wrong signal, and risk damaging the national reputation in the eyes of the global audience (Fenton-Smith, 2007). This type of public diplomacy is also indicative of Harrell and Linkugel’s aforementioned *reaffirmation* rhetoric; in this case, the rhetor was expected to engage in epideictic discourse in order to galvanize foreign opinions about American values, and in this case, its commitment to bilateral relations with the Palestinian nation.

To further illustrate this point, while seemingly a different example of rhetoric altogether, Presidential missile defense advocacy is aimed at managing foreign perceptions about the intent of U.S. policymakers. Specifically, this particular discourse is aimed at generating foreign public support for the deployment of American ballistic missile defenses (BMD). Convincing the Russian media, public, and elites of the benign intent of missile defenses, and creating the perception of friendship and mutual protection was the central rhetorical strategy in George W. Bush’s diplomatic campaign to market BMD (Gerber, 2007). This type of foreign policy discourse could be categorized and explained by Harrell and Linkugel’s rhetoric of affirmation, in which the rhetor must convince an audience to adopt a new image, concept or idea; in this case, the construction of American missile defenses in Poland. Consideration of public diplomacy from the perspective of ‘national image

management' also invites investigation from the public relations and 'place branding' approaches to communication mentioned previously.

One common feature in all of the aforementioned examples is the government-to-public nature of the communication. This factor represents a third categorical similarity within the substance of the arguments made during the exercise of public diplomacy, and also clearly invites investigation from Benoit's perspective in which the role of the agent (government) determines which rhetorical strategies are most likely to resonate with the audience (agency).

Indeed, this feature of public diplomacy was directly established by Vincour (1957), a communications scholar, when he argued that "modern diplomacy no longer consists solely of governments speaking to governments; today it requires that ambassadors speak directly to the people" (p.201). Vincour drew upon the earlier work of Margaret Mead, who "emphasized the importance of cross-national communication" (p.203). Gerstman (1962) noted that public diplomacy entailed the "government appealing directly to the people" (p.19).

To illustrate this characteristic, I briefly compare two admittedly different types of public diplomacy; first, America's al-Hurra public television broadcasts, and second, newly elected U.S. President Barack Obama's recent interview on Arab television station al-Arabiya, in which he sought to "speak directly to the Arab world" (Ghazi, 2009). Al-Hurra, a U.S.-funded TV station broadcasting in Arab countries with a stated goal of promoting a "positive image of the United States," is an example of the government speaking directly to a foreign public audience, attempting to influence and control perceptions about the United States, and ultimately to manage national reputation (Linzer, 2008). Al-Hurra broadcasts a mixture of Arabic and English language news and popular music, but it became viewed as a tool of American propaganda, and was widely criticized (at

least domestically), for ‘pandering’ to its Arab viewers (Mowbray, 2007). This example seems to invite interrogation from Harrell and Linkugel’s theory of *subversive* rhetorical situations. After the attacks of September 11th, the United States, faced with a perceived situation in which anti-American sentiment and ideology was beginning to directly challenge its military and economic supremacy, responded with a rhetorical move to subvert and undercut those ideologies. However, the role of the U.S. as rhetor in terms of how the U.S. was perceived by Muslim audiences created a situation in which the al-Hurra strategies were viewed as propaganda. The “representations of the American ideology of universal egalitarianism” were transparent and positioned the U.S. as a “blameless victim of misguided terrorists” (Plaisance, 2005, pp.259-260). Without commenting on the truth of this claim, it is nonetheless clear that the role of the rhetor played a prominent part in determining the ultimate impact of the messages upon the target audience.

President Obama’s interview was in a similar venue, had a similar rhetorical goal, and represented government-to-public diplomatic communication, but the *strategies* and outcome were different. Obama, as the highest representative of the American government, created identification and solidarity with his audience by saying “I have Muslim members of my family,” and that “I have lived in Muslim countries” (Melham, 2009). As a way to distance himself from ‘antecedent’ rhetorical forms, Obama also refused to endorse or employ the phrase “War on Terrorism” (Baldor, 2009). Obama’s rhetoric represented “part of a concerted effort to repair relations with the Muslim world that were damaged under the previous administration” (Schreck, 2009). Like the al-Hurra television broadcasts, Obama’s interview can be classified and analyzed as government-to-public communication, but the role of the rhetor is markedly different, and clearly influenced the rhetorical strategies that were employed. Indeed, it seems that Obama’s strategy was

wholly concerned with changing the image of the rhetor, the United States government. Obama's rhetoric was not *subversive*, but was rather aimed at what Harrell and Linkugel would call *purification*. Obama's goal was to restore the tarnished image of the United States in Muslim public opinion. I have only briefly discussed the effectiveness of these two examples, for it is the identification of the variations in the category, the differences and departures from the genre that make this type of criticism rich and relevant. Generic categorization of rhetoric is a tool that provides critics with another way of analyzing types of rhetoric; in this case, public diplomacy. Measell (1976), a communications scholar who identified the "rhetoric of diplomacy" as a genre, put it this way: "The purpose of criticism by genres is not so much to classify as to *clarify*" (p.1).

A generic, situational approach to the classification and analysis of public diplomacy yields a fourth potential benefit for critics: the ability to chart changes in the trajectory of diplomatic rhetoric over time, specifically in the context of international relations. For example, a generic approach would invite investigations of the ways in which American (or Soviet/Russian) public diplomacy changed (or remained the same) from the period of the Cold War, to the current period of multipolarity and global concern about terrorism. Der Derian's (1987) *On Diplomacy* is illustrative of this type of criticism. Der Derian employed a Foucauldian genealogy to retrace the evolutions of diplomacy as genre of discourse, and to render alternate narratives regarding both the theoretical import and function of diplomatic language in international relations. While Der Derian would likely resist being 'claimed' as a communication scholar, his ideological and methodological approach would support that classification. Indeed, much of Der Derian's argument relies upon identification of the ways in which diplomatic discourse has evolved in relation to both its audience and to changes in the international situation. For Der Derian,

diplomacy and “diplomatic culture” was an endeavor permeated by and created by mythology, symbolism, and exigency (p.49). Perhaps this type of approach might also help to explain public diplomacy in an era of ‘paradigm gap’ in which no “overarching goals, no single paradigm” provides “direction for large elements of America’s engagement abroad” (Hunter, 2000). Critics could also choose to focus on the ways in which bilateral public diplomacy changed between two (or more) nations, based upon changes in the international situation. For example, public diplomatic relations between the United States and Iran have been non-existent for nearly three decades, but the investigation of subtle changes in how the Obama administration publicly communicates with Iran are clearly warranted (Gordon & Zeleny, 2007). Genre criticism represents a way to uncover subtle (or overt) deviations in the substance, style, form, and function of public diplomacy based upon changes in the predominant global situation or context.

Conclusions

I have attempted to demonstrate, albeit briefly, the potential value in approaching public diplomacy from a generic rhetorical perspective. Specifically, I have argued that viewing public diplomacy as a genre of rhetoric yields insight into both the definitional problems associated with the emergence of this field, and to the ways in which public diplomacy is deployed discursively and strategically. Viewing public diplomacy as a rhetorical genre provides a critical tool to isolate and explicate the factors that are a permanent part of discourse, and the ones that change over time. Generic criticism is an approach that has been traditionally concerned with analysis of rhetoric in response to a situation. I hope to have demonstrated that a situational approach to the classification and study of public diplomacy is both appropriate and useful to critics. I have argued that public diplomacy constitutes a genre of rhetoric, and that it is

best defined as the ongoing discursive management of national reputation.

This article has also hopefully cast new light on the rich tradition of the examination of public diplomacy that has taken place in the field of communication studies. To be clear, I am not arguing that the study of public diplomacy hasn't taken place in other academic fields, nor am I arguing that future research in this area shouldn't be undertaken from a variety of methodological and disciplinary approaches. Rather, this article merely sought to posit that there is indeed a bedrock of seminal, foundational literature on public diplomacy to be found in the field of communication studies. In particular, while I am willing to concede that other fields (most notably political science) have provided meaningful insight into the function of public diplomacy, I conclude that due to the common *suasive* elements that recurrently appear in this type of discourse, rhetorical approaches to the study of public diplomacy are the most appropriate.

As an aside, my argument in this particular article was for the critical consideration of public diplomacy (at a 'macro' level) as a rhetorical genre. I have identified four common characteristics that recur in public diplomacy, and I argue that these commonalities necessitate the consideration of public diplomacy as a genre of rhetoric. This conclusion is not meant to exclude the consideration of 'sub-genres' within the larger genus of public diplomacy. It could rather easily be argued that foreign policy apologia, for example, is a recurrent species of discourse with similar situational exigencies that call forth a particular strategic response. In fact, given the vast and constantly evolving nature of global international relations, there are potentially many sub-genres of public diplomacy. The thrust of this essay is to begin to demonstrate the potential of the generic approach to enrich the study of public diplomacy and its sub-genres, particularly from the academic lens of communication studies.

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Matthew Gerber is an Assistant Professor and Director of Debate in Communication Studies at Baylor University.

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